

Feminism and Bangladesh: Advanced Quiz

Topic: Feminism and Bangladesh | Difficulty: Hard | Questions: 5 | Model: gemini-2.5-flash

1. Bangladesh operates under a system where personal laws, largely derived from religious scriptures, govern matters like marriage, divorce, and inheritance. Which of the following statements accurately reflects a significant challenge or characteristic of this system concerning women's rights in Bangladesh?

A. The uniform application of the Muslim Family Laws Ordinance (MFLO) 1961 has successfully harmonized all religious personal laws, ensuring equal rights for women across all faiths.

B. Despite constitutional guarantees of equality, the absence of a Uniform Family Code means that women from different religious communities face disparate legal provisions regarding personal status, often disadvantaging non-Muslim women more severely in areas like divorce and inheritance. (correct)

C. The Bangladeshi Supreme Court has consistently ruled to prioritize secular civil codes over religious personal laws in all matters pertaining to women's inheritance rights, establishing a precedent for gender equality.

D. The government has fully implemented the recommendations of the Law Commission to abolish all religious personal laws and replace them with a single, gender-neutral civil code, effective nationwide.

Explanation: Bangladesh lacks a Uniform Family Code, leading to different personal laws for different religious communities. Historically, non-Muslim women, particularly Hindu women, faced significant disadvantages in areas like divorce and inheritance compared to their Muslim counterparts, though some reforms have been made, the disparity persists.

2. The ready-made garment (RMG) sector has been a significant driver of female employment in Bangladesh. However, its contribution to women's empowerment is often debated. Which of the following represents a critical, nuanced critique of the RMG sector's impact on Bangladeshi women's empowerment, beyond mere employment figures?

A. The RMG sector has universally led to women's increased autonomy in household decision-making and a significant reduction in gender-based violence due to their economic independence.

B. While providing employment, the sector often confines women to low-skill, low-wage positions with limited upward mobility, perpetuating a gendered division of labor and exposing them to precarious working conditions and exploitation. (correct)

C. The primary challenge for women in the RMG sector is the lack of access to microfinance loans, which prevents them from starting their own garment businesses.

D. The RMG industry has successfully eradicated child marriage in areas with high factory concentrations due to the economic necessity of adult female labor.

Explanation: While the RMG sector provides employment, a common critique is that it often traps women in precarious, low-wage jobs with limited opportunities for advancement, reinforcing existing gender inequalities rather than fundamentally transforming them, and exposing them to various forms of exploitation.

3. Bangladesh introduced reserved seats for women in the national parliament (Jatiya Sangsad) and local government bodies. Which statement best describes a persistent challenge or a critical perspective regarding the effectiveness of these quota systems in advancing substantive feminist goals in Bangladesh?

A. The reserved seats have consistently led to a significant increase in women's legislative influence, with women representatives primarily advocating for gender-specific legislation over party lines.

B. While increasing numerical representation, critics argue that the indirect election process for reserved parliamentary seats often results in women representatives being less accountable to constituents and more beholden to party leadership, limiting their independent agency. (correct)

C. The quota system has been universally praised by feminist organizations in Bangladesh for fully addressing the structural barriers to women's political leadership.

D. The primary challenge is the lack of male support for women in politics, rather than any structural issues with the quota system itself.

Explanation: A key critique of the reserved seats in the national parliament is that they are filled through indirect election by elected male MPs, making these women representatives more accountable to their party leadership than to the general electorate, thus potentially limiting their independent advocacy for women's issues.

4. Non-governmental organizations (NGOs) have played a pivotal role in advocating for women's rights in Bangladesh, particularly since the 1980s. However, their approach and impact have also drawn critiques. Which of the following represents a significant, hard-level critique often leveled against the NGO-led feminist movement in Bangladesh?

A. NGOs have largely failed to secure any legislative changes related to women's rights, focusing instead solely on service delivery.

B. A common critique is that many large NGOs, often funded by international donors, adopt a 'depoliticized' or 'developmentalist' approach to women's issues, sometimes overlooking deeper structural inequalities or local, grassroots feminist agendas in favor of project-based outcomes. (correct)

C. Bangladeshi NGOs have been criticized for exclusively focusing on urban elite women's issues, completely neglecting rural and marginalized women.

D. The primary criticism is that NGOs have actively discouraged women's participation in formal politics, preferring to keep women's activism within the non-profit sector.

Explanation: Many scholars and activists critique large, internationally funded NGOs for often adopting a 'developmentalist' framework that focuses on measurable project outcomes (e.g., microcredit, health services) rather than challenging fundamental power structures or supporting more radical, grassroots feminist movements, thereby 'depoliticizing' women's issues.

5. The rise of religious conservatism in Bangladesh has presented complex challenges to women's rights advocacy. Which of the following scenarios best illustrates a specific, hard-level manifestation of this challenge in contemporary Bangladesh?

A. The complete abolition of all women's education initiatives by religious fundamentalist groups across the country.

B. The widespread public acceptance and state endorsement of fatwas issued by local religious leaders that directly contradict existing secular laws protecting women's rights, leading to impunity for perpetrators of gender-based violence. (correct)

C. The government's proactive implementation of a uniform civil code, despite religious opposition, to ensure gender equality in all personal matters.

D. The complete withdrawal of women from the public workforce due to religious pressure, leading to a collapse of the garment industry.

Explanation: A significant challenge is the issuance of fatwas by religious leaders that often contradict secular laws, particularly concerning women's rights (e.g., divorce, domestic violence). While not always legally binding, these fatwas can hold significant social sway, undermine the rule of law, and contribute to impunity for gender-based violence, especially in rural areas.

Answer Key

- 1. B** Despite constitutional guarantees of equality, the absence of a Uniform Family Code means that women from different religious communities face disparate legal provisions regarding personal status, often disadvantaging non-Muslim women more severely in areas like divorce and inheritance.
- 2. B** While providing employment, the sector often confines women to low-skill, low-wage positions with limited upward mobility, perpetuating a gendered division of labor and exposing them to precarious working conditions and exploitation.
- 3. B** While increasing numerical representation, critics argue that the indirect election process for reserved parliamentary seats often results in women representatives being less accountable to constituents and more beholden to party leadership, limiting their independent agency.
- 4. B** A common critique is that many large NGOs, often funded by international donors, adopt a 'depoliticized' or 'developmentalist' approach to women's issues, sometimes overlooking deeper structural inequalities or local, grassroots feminist agendas in favor of project-based outcomes.
- 5. B** The widespread public acceptance and state endorsement of fatwas issued by local religious leaders that directly contradict existing secular laws protecting women's rights, leading to impunity for perpetrators of gender-based violence.